

Snapshot of core views

Who can reach your kid, and how?

A parent's guide to phone alternatives: home, a sample family plan, the tech radar, devices, the debates, and country profiles.

Captured September 23, 2026. Sample family: United States, age 9, home and school every day, comfortable with a live location map.

Interactive features (sliders, live news, carousel, page turning) work in the online version.

A GUIDE FOR PARENTS

Who can reach your kid, and how?

Find the right first device for your child, from a kids' landline to a smartwatch, in about two minutes. Then see who can reach them, where, and on whose terms.

Your kid's age

9

▼

Where you live

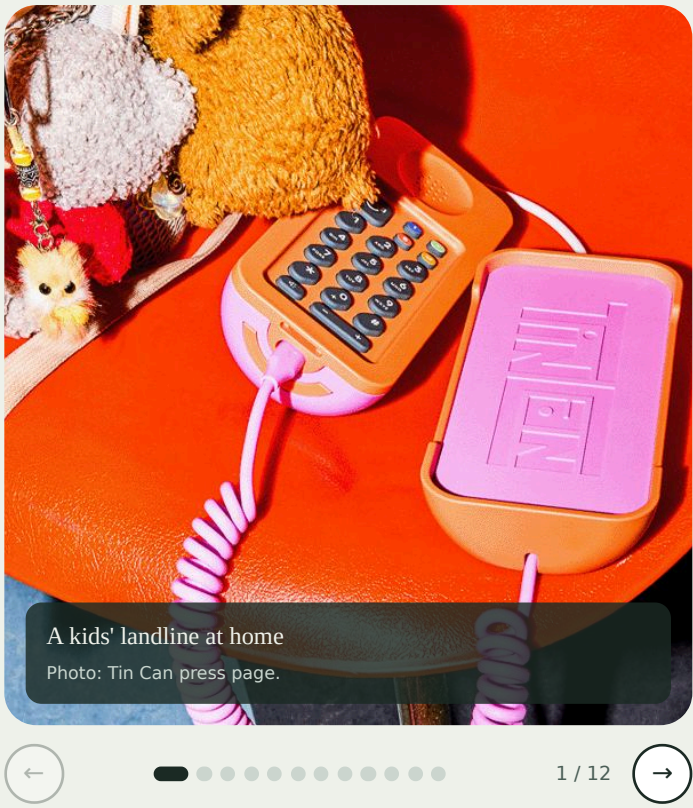
United States

▼

Start my plan

Welcome back. Your plan for United States, age 9: top pick **Gabb Watch 3e**. [Open my plan](#)

- 13 devices compared
- 31 country profiles
- Every claim linked to a source
- Last checked September 23, 2026
- Your answers stay in your browser



A kids' landline at home
Photo: Tin Can press page.

- 1

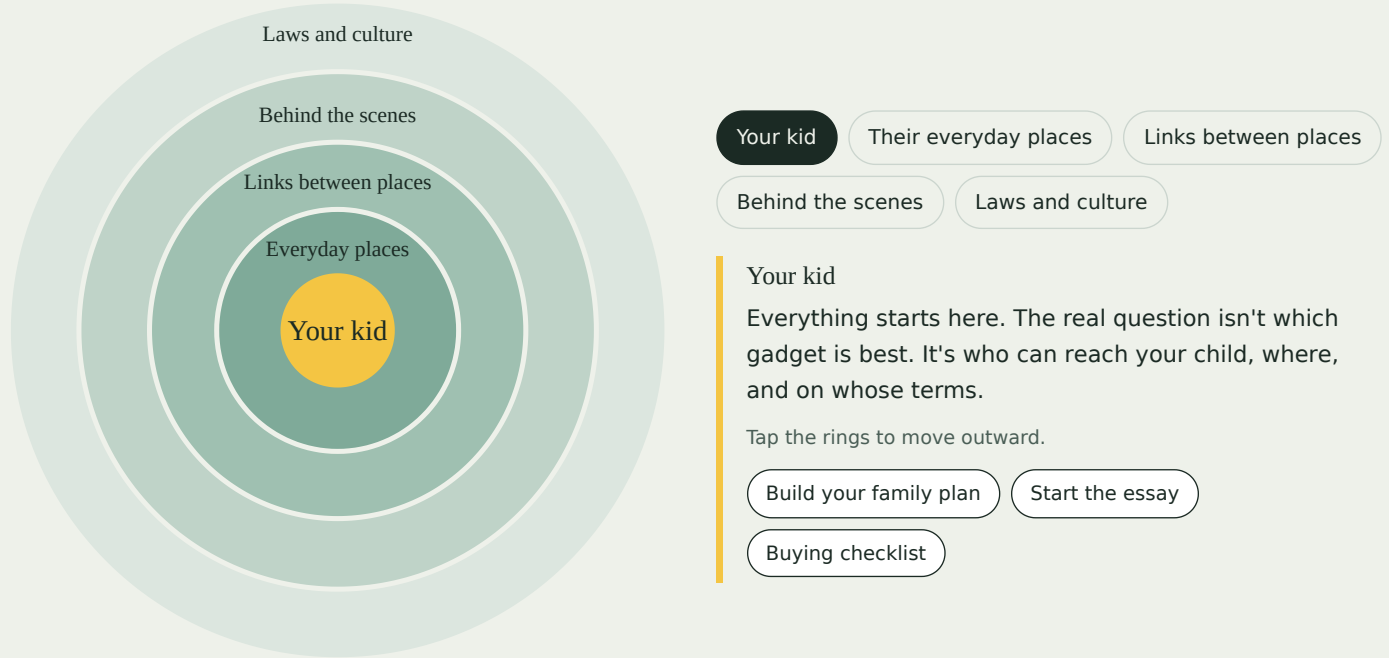
Tell us about your kid
Where they go, and what you're comfortable with: tracking, messaging, apps, camera.
- 2

See your best fits
Devices ranked for your family, plus a tech radar of every feature, placed by your comfort levels.
- 3

Understand the debates
What critics worry about, what your country's rules say, and the latest news.

The big idea

Choosing a device isn't only about the gadget. It's about the circles around your child. Tap a ring to explore each one.



Next: Your plan

The rings are based on Urie Bronfenbrenner's ecological model of child development, renamed in everyday words:

Their everyday places	Microsystem
Links between places	Mesosystem
Behind the scenes	Exosystem
Laws and culture	Macrosystem
Pick by age	Chronosystem

Recommendations

Tech radar

Build your family plan

Pick your country, drag the places your kid goes, and set what you're comfortable with. Your plan updates the map, the gallery, the news, and the last page of the essay. It stays in this browser only.

1. Where you live

Continent

North America

Country

United States

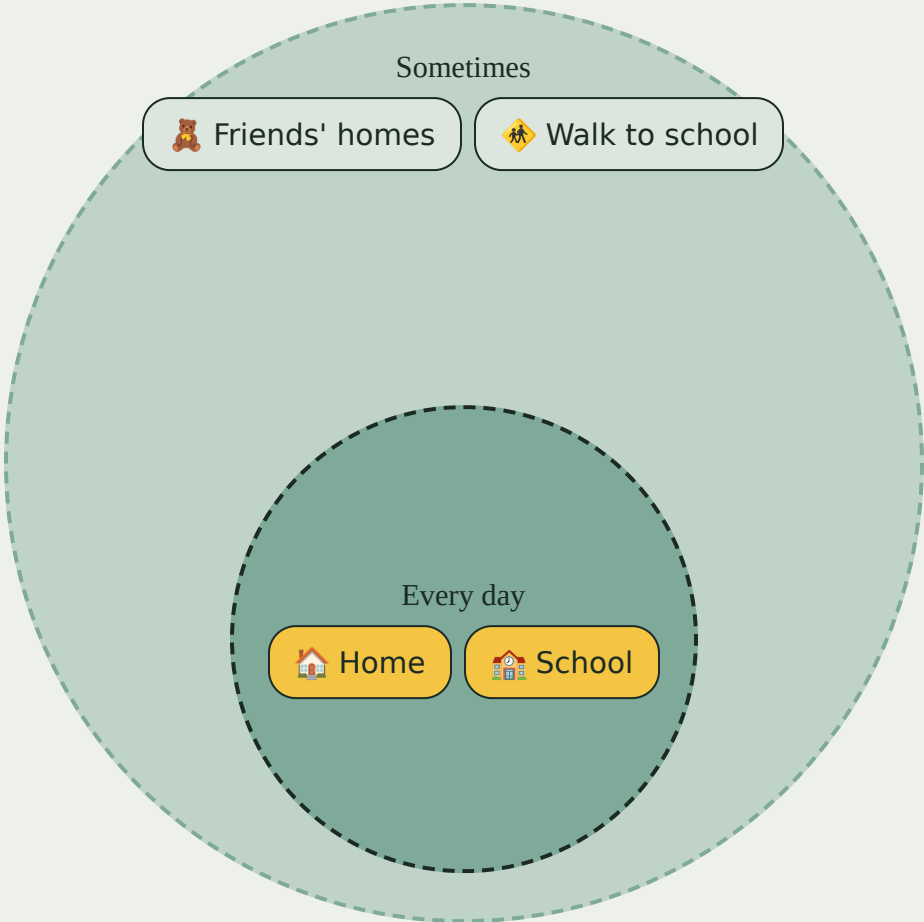
Moderate

The US leaves school phone rules to states and has no national social media age limit beyond data rules for under-13s.

See the full country profile

2. Where your kid goes

Drag each place onto the rings: the center for every day, the outer ring for sometimes. Or tap a place to move it along.



Not really



Park and neighborhood



Trails and camping



Travel

3. What you're comfortable with

Location tracking

Live map

Messaging friends

A few friends

Apps and games

Clock and steps

Reading their messages

Only if worried

Camera and photos

Photos to me

Your kid's age

9

Balanced

63

Family privacy score. Higher means less data about your kid, and fewer people who can reach them.

Reach you need

Best fits for your family

1. **Gabb Watch 3e** 90% fit

Covers home, friends' homes, school, walk to school. Goes past your comfort on messaging.

Source: [SafeWise](#)

2. **Garmin Bounce 2** 80% fit

Covers home, friends' homes, school, walk to school. Goes past your comfort on messaging, apps.

Source: [Garmin newsroom](#) Also: [Stiftung Warentest via Notebookcheck](#)

3. **Verizon Gizmo Watch 4** 70% fit

Covers home, friends' homes, school, walk to school. Goes past your comfort on messaging, message reading, camera.

Source: [Forbes Vetted](#)

Fit scores are estimates from published reviews and product pages. Check each device yourself before buying.

► How we score this

Copy my plan

Print

Start over

Back: Home

Next: Devices

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Your tech radar

Every device and feature, placed by the comfort levels in your plan. Move a slider and watch things shift between rings. Select any dot to learn what it is and why people disagree about it.



Location and safety

10. Live location map

Good fit now

A parent can see where the child is at any time.

Within your comfort on tracking.

The debate: Location data about children sits with the company, and in 2017 Norway's consumer council found some watches could be taken over by strangers to track kids. Some parents also worry that constant tracking leaves kids less room to build independence.

[Learn more: Live location tracking](#)

▼ Your comfort levels

Location tracking



Live map

Messaging friends



A few friends

Apps and games



Clock and steps

Reading their messages



Only if worried

Camera and photos



Photos to me

Your kid's age



9

Good fit now

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- 25 Camera for photos

Try with care

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- 12 Watch removal alerts
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- 18 Video calls
- 23 Games

Look into first

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- 24 Music
- 26 Sharing photos with friends

Hold off

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Devices

Ranked for your family plan. Filter by where your kid will use it, or scroll down for a quick guide by place and age. Badges show how each device fits the comfort levels you set. **Last checked September 23, 2026.**

Devices by place

- All places
- Home
- Friends' homes
- School
- Walk to school
- Park and neighborhood
- Trails and camping
- Travel

☐ Only devices sold in my country

Your top 3 fits, based on your plan.



Photo: Gabb website.
Home, Friends' homes, School and more
Gabb Watch 3e
Calls, texts, and GPS with no internet or apps. SafeWise's best first smartwatch.

Over your comfort on messaging

Source: [SafeWise](#)



Home, Friends' homes, School and more
Garmin Bounce 2
Two-way calling, texting, live location, games, and music, announced September 2025. The original Bounce couldn't make calls but had the best location tracking in Stiftung Warentest's test.

Over your comfort on messaging, apps

Source: [Garmin newsroom](#)
Also: [Stiftung Warentest via Notebookcheck](#)



Home, Friends' homes, School and more
Verizon Gizmo Watch 4
Calls, texts, GPS, school mode, a camera, and video calls with up to 40 contacts. Forbes' top pick for young kids.

Over your comfort on messaging, message reading, camera

Source: [Forbes Vetted](#)

See all 13 devices

Quick guide: pick by place

Every device only reaches as far as its signal. Start at home and move outward.

1



Photo: Tin Can press page.
Home
Kids' landline
Example: Tin Can, a Wi-Fi phone that only rings for people you approve.
Good for: ages 6 to 10 calling friends and grandparents on their own.
Watch out: it stops working where your Wi-Fi ends.

2



Photo: Jun Ren on Unsplash.
School
Nothing, or school mode
Why: more schools ban phones during the day, and some now ban watches too.
Good for: a watch with school mode that locks everything but emergencies.
Watch out: check your school's rules before you buy.

3



Photo: Cosmo press page.
Neighborhood
Cellular kids' watch
Examples: Gabb, Verizon Gizmo, Bark. Calls, texts, GPS, and an SOS button.
Good for: the walk to school, the park, a friend's house.
Watch out: monthly plans, and contacts you have to keep updated.

4



Photo: Spacetalk.
Outdoors
Walkie-talkies
Why: watches need cell signal. Radios talk directly to each other.
Good for: camping, trails, big parks, the beach.
Watch out: for real backcountry, an adult should carry a satellite messenger.

Quick guide: pick by age

Rough guides based on how reviewers group these products. Your kid's maturity matters more than the number.

6+ Kids' landline Voice only. Learning to call, answer, and make plans without borrowing your phone.	8+ Simple kids' watch Calls and texts with approved contacts, plus location. No internet, no apps.	12+ Teen watch An Apple Watch with Family Setup opens group chats. It's a bridge toward a phone, not a replacement.	14+ First phone If and when you decide. Many families wait until at least the end of 8th grade.
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Questions to ask before you buy

One for each ring.

1**Where will my kid actually use it?**
Home, school, around town, or outdoors. Match the device to the place.

2**Who else will be on it?**
If friends need the same brand to talk, expect pressure to buy it, and watch for features that turn chats into a popularity contest.

3**What can the company add later?**
Games, likes, and app stores can arrive in an update. Check what you can turn off.

4**What will I be able to see and hear?**
Location is one thing. Secret listening crosses a line, and in some countries it's illegal.

5**What does my school allow?**
Rules are changing fast. Ask before the first day, not after.

Back: Your plan

Next: Learn

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Learn the tech, and the debates

Each topic explains what the technology does, why parents choose it, and what critics worry about, with sources for both sides.

Live location tracking

Scanning or reading messages

Closed kid networks, likes, and rankings

Secret listen-in features

Security of kids' devices

Social media age bans

School phone and watch bans

Screen time limits

Back to the landline

Live location tracking

Kids' watches report where a child is to a parent's app, often with safe zones that send an alert when a child leaves school or arrives home.

Why parents choose it

It's the main reason parents buy these watches: reaching a child and knowing they got there, without handing over a smartphone.

What critics worry about

Location data about children sits with the company, and in 2017 Norway's consumer council found some watches could be taken over by strangers to track kids. Some parents also worry that constant tracking leaves kids less room to build independence.

Sources: [Norwegian Consumer Council: #WatchOut](#) · [Forbes Vetted: best kids smartwatches](#)

[See related items on your tech radar](#)

Read the essay

The same story, told start to finish. Turn the pages with the buttons, your arrow keys, or a swipe.

The watch instead of the phone

What five countries teach parents about kids and connection.

1 of 10

Your kid

Previous page

Page 1 of 10

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Next: Around the world

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Country profiles

Where each country stands on phones in schools, social media age limits, and children's data. Last checked September 23, 2026.

Strict: national rules in force Moderate: some national or strong regional rules Emerging: debates and draft laws

Africa

- Namibia

Senegal

South Africa
- Nigeria

Kenya

Egypt

Asia

- China

Singapore

South Korea
- Japan

India

Indonesia
- Philippines

Europe

- Germany

Norway
- United Kingdom

Poland
- Luxembourg

France
- Netherlands

Spain

Italy

North America

- United States

Canada

Mexico

Oceania

- Australia

New Zealand

South America

- Brazil

Argentina

Chile
- Colombia

United States Moderate Some national or strong regional rules

The US leaves school phone rules to states and has no national social media age limit beyond data rules for under-13s.

Phones and devices at school

No federal rule. By 2025-26 many states required districts to restrict phones and personal devices; smartwatch coverage varies. New York's ban is bell to bell.

Covers smartwatches: Not stated

Children's data and online safety law

Children's Online Privacy Protection Act (COPPA), 1998.

Social media and age

COPPA requires parental consent to collect data from under-13s. State age laws vary and face court challenges.

Worth knowing

Kids' watches are sold as walled gardens with parent-approved contacts.

Sources: AP: states restrict cellphones in schools · Bond, Schoeneck & King: New York's school ban

Use United States in my plan

News from United States

What other countries learned

The same watch means something different depending on the rules and culture around it.

China

About one in three kids wears a smartwatch, mostly from one brand. Its watches only message each other, and kids add friends by bumping wrists. Likes and rankings followed, then peer pressure and a black market for likes.

A closed network can turn into a kids' social network.

Australia

Social media is banned for kids under 16 since December 2025. Watch makers now market themselves as the approved alternative. Months in, many parents say kids still get onto the apps.

Laws help, but they only work if platforms follow them.

Singapore

Secondary schools now ban smartwatches along with phones, including at recess and after-school activities.

Some schools no longer see watches as the safe middle ground.

United States

Many brands, each sold as a walled garden: no internet, no social media, parent-approved contacts only. Kids still ask for phones, because that's where their friends are.

A watch buys time. It doesn't end the phone conversation.

Germany

In 2017, regulators banned kids' watches with a hidden listen-in feature after parents used them to eavesdrop on teachers.

Watching your kid too closely can become its own problem.

A smaller screen doesn't stop social media. It just shrinks it.

News by country

Curated stories last checked September 23, 2026.

Continent

North America

Country

United States

Search these stories

Try school, ban, or watch

All rings

Everyday places

Links between places

Behind the scenes

Laws and culture

9 curated stories for United States.

Machine Society, Nov 2025 China, United States

Links between places

How kids' smartwatches led to anxiety, addiction, and crime

Why it matters: The clearest comparison of China and the US.

Samsung newsroom, Sep 2026 United States

Everyday places

Bark and Samsung launch a new kids' smartwatch

Why it matters: The Bark Watch now runs on Samsung Galaxy Watch8 hardware.

Stock Titan (Verizon release), Jul 2026 United States

Everyday places

Meet the Gizmo Watch 4: Verizon's new kid-friendly smartwatch

Why it matters: Adds alerts when the watch is taken off, plus school mode.

Garmin newsroom, Sep 2025 United States

Everyday places

Parents can delay the smartphone with Bounce 2

Why it matters: Garmin's kids' watch now makes two-way calls.

Forbes Vetted, Aug 2026 United States

Everyday places

The best kids smartwatches, according to hands-on family testing

Why it matters: Gizmo Watch 4 for young kids, Apple Watch SE 3 for tweens.

SafeWise, 2026 United States

Everyday places

Best smartwatches for kids, tested by parents and kids

Why it matters: Bark Watch overall, Gabb as the best first watch.

Reviewed, 2025 United States

Everyday places

The best smartwatches for kids

Why it matters: A second parent-tested opinion.

Bond, Schoeneck & King, May 2025 United States

Laws and culture

New York's bell-to-bell school smartphone ban

Why it matters: Covers all internet-enabled devices, not just phones.

Tin Can, 2026 United States, Canada, Australia, New Zealand, United Kingdom

Links between places

The landline, reinvented for kids

Why it matters: A kids' phone network that spreads one neighborhood at a time.

Search the latest news for United States on Google News

Live news

Live search works when this page is opened in Claude by someone with the Exa connector. Until then, use the curated stories and the Google News link above.

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